DEPARTMENT OF STATE

CONFIDENTIAL

Memorandum of Conversation

DATE: February 6, 1953

SUBJECT: Canadian Inquiry Concerning President Eisenhower's Reference in His State of the Union Message Requesting Congress to Join in an Appropriate Resolution Regarding "Secret Understandings of the Past"

PARTICIPANTS:

Mr. George Ignatieff, Counselor, Canadian Embassy
Mr. B. A. Wallis, Second Secretary, Canadian Embassy
Mr. Richard H. Davis, EE

COPIES TO:

C - Mr. Bohlen
EUR - Mr. Bonbright
BNA - Mr. Brown
EE - Messrs. Barbour, Vedeler and Leverich
P - Mr. MacKnight
S/P - Mr. Ferguson
H -
FE -
L -

Bureau of FAR EASTERN AFFAIRS
FEB 10 1953
ASSISTANT SECRETARY
Department of State

U. S. GOVERNMENT PRINTING OFFICE 16—61120-1

At his request Mr. Ignatieff called on me this morning and read to me portions of a debate in the Canadian Parliament on February 2, 1953, during which Mr. Drew, Leader of the Progressive-Conservative Party (Opposition), questioned the Prime Minister, Mr. St. Laurent, concerning the following statement of President Eisenhower in his State of the Union Message on February 2:

> "(3) Our policy, dedicated to making the free world secure, will envision all peaceful methods and devices -- except breaking faith with our friends. We shall never acquiesce in the enslavement of any people in order to purchase fancied gain for ourselves. I shall ask the Congress at a later date to join in an appropriate resolution making clear that this government recognizes no kind of commitment contained in secret understandings of the past with foreign governments which permit this kind of enslavement."

Mr. Ignatieff commented that Mr. St. Laurent had been very cautious in his reply to Mr. Drew's questioning. He said the Government would soon be subject to further questioning in Parliament and desired any additional information which could be given it so that an appropriate reply could be made to the Opposition.

I said

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SUBJECT:

I said that no decision had been reached as yet on the implementation of the President's statement before Congress, that the matter was under study and that while the President's statement indicated a draft resolution would be submitted to the Congress by the Executive Branch of the Government, no details had as yet been worked out. Mr. Ignatieff inquired about the phrase "secret understandings of the past" and speculated whether it meant in general all agreements reached during the War or only particular parts thereof. He referred especially to those portions of the Yalta and Berlin Agreements which dealt with territorial questions in Europe and the Far East.

I replied that in my own opinion it probably referred to certain portions of the Yalta and Potsdam Agreements and I pointed out that these were executive agreements which had never been submitted to Congress whereas the peace treaties with the Satellites and with Italy had, as required by the Constitution, been approved by the Senate.

In conclusion, Mr. Ignatieff said that he would advise Ottawa that this matter was still under consideration in Washington and that the Canadian Government should be careful in making any statement pending a final decision of the new Administration in regard to the kind of a resolution which it would submit to the Congress. He asked tb be kept informed of any developments which the Department might be able to give him.

EUR:EE:RHDavis:all
2/9/53

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